

Semantifying Genomic Variant Data: VCF to RDF Conversion Framework



Elias Crum^{1,2}, Ruben Taelman¹, Bart Buelens², Gokhan Ertaylan², Ruben Verborgh¹

¹IDLab, Department of Electronics and Information Systems, Ghent University – imec, Belgium

²Flemish institute for Technological Research (VITO) Mol, Belgium

Abstract

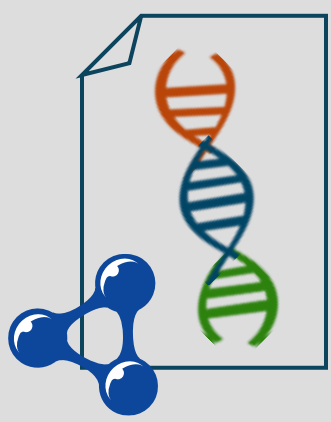
Variant Call Format (VCF) files, the standard for representing patient genomic variant data, face limitations in interoperability, data linking, querying, and semantic interpretability. We propose a framework for converting VCF data into semantic data using the Resource Description Framework (RDF) to address these limitations. Our approach includes a comprehensive ontology, a storage-efficient RDF representation using Header Dictionary Triples (HDT), and integration with clinical metadata schemas like that proposed by SPHN. Our framework and the representation of VCF data semantically will contribute to greater integration, scalability, and usability of these genomic variant data in both genomic medicine and research.

Genome Data for Clinical Use

Predominantly VCF format



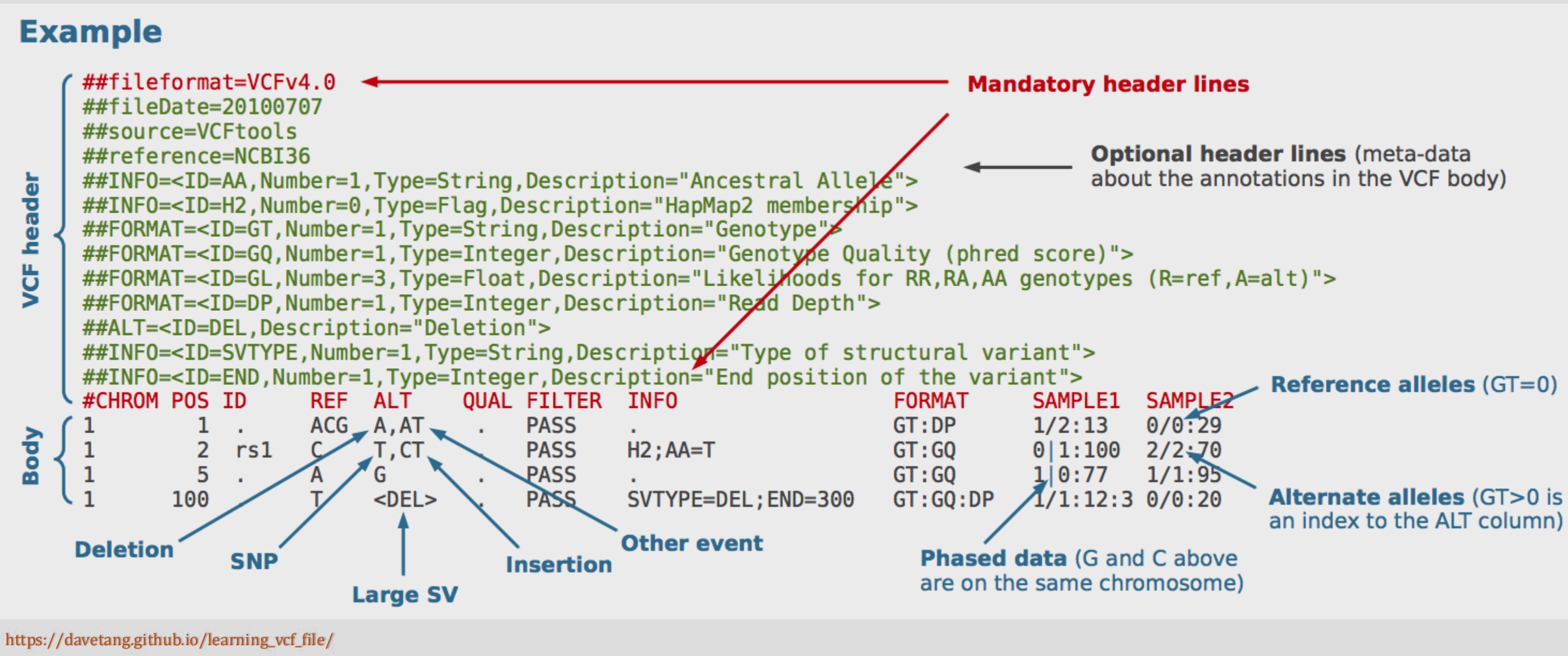
Objective



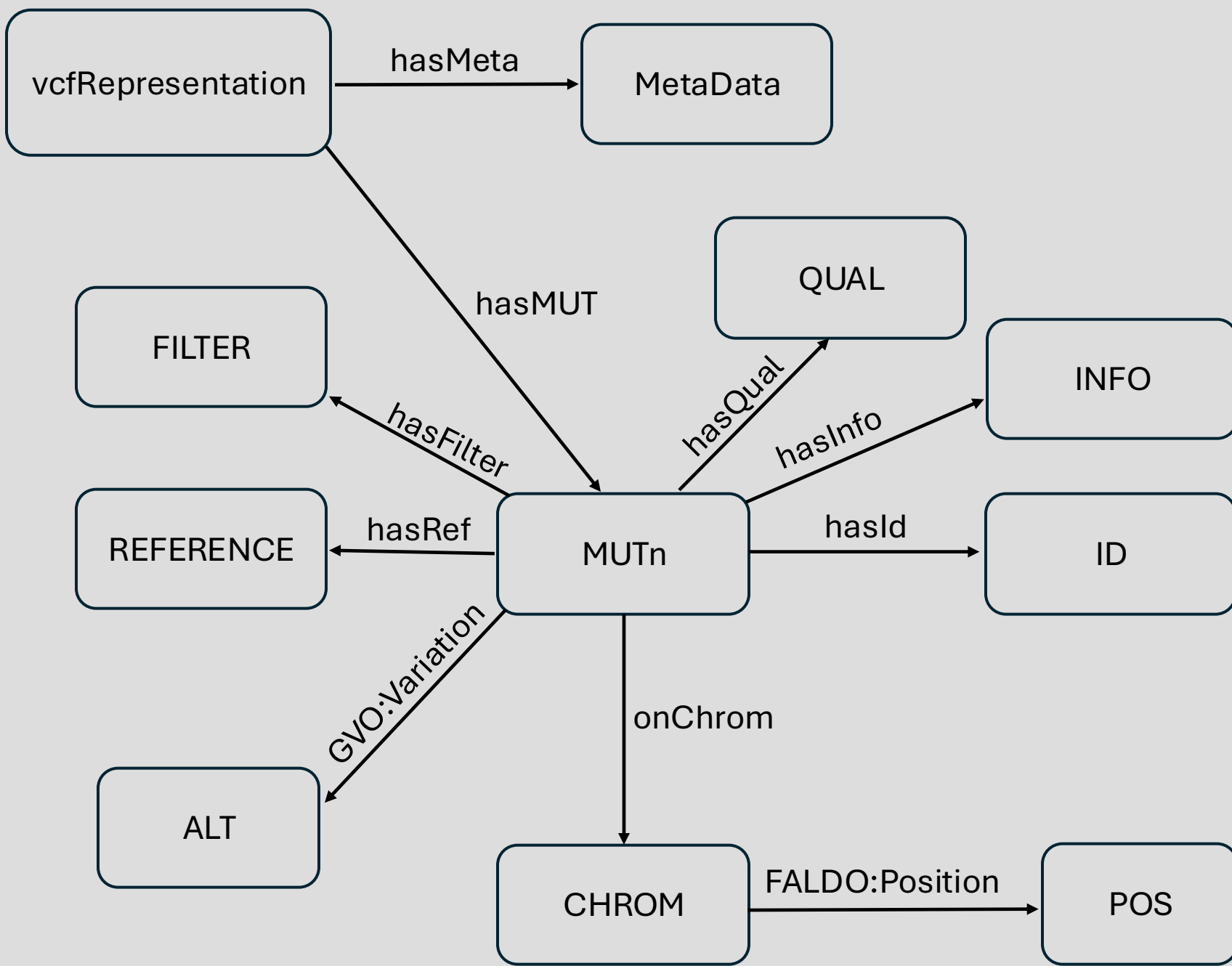
Represent VCF data semantically using RDF

Proposed Framework

VCF Anatomy



VCF Ontology Visualization



FALDO – <https://bioportal.bioontology.org/ontologies/FALDO>
GVO – <http://genome-variation.org/resource/gvo>

Conversion Framework

Existing Solutions:

- vcf2rdf -- <https://github.com/togovar/vcf2rdf>

PROBLEM: (extremely lightweight and does not represent all data within VCF file)

- SPARQLing-genomics -- <https://gitlab.com/roeli/sparqling-genomics>

PROBLEM: (uses proprietary vcf ontology + no longer maintained)

Proposed Solution:

- RDF Mapping Language (RML) -- <https://github.com/RMLio/rmlmapper-java>



WHY:

- NOT hardcoded into a conversion script
- Flexible (allows ontology evolution/extension)
- Established tool
- Offers methods for documentation generation

Future Directions

- Public Ontology Publication
- Pharmacogenomic health data linking
- Implementation Development



Contact